SHIPS WITH ENGINES

Wind is not a very reliable form of power—sometimes it blows from the wrong direction, and sometimes it does not blow at all! But from around 1800, steam engines were used to turn paddle wheels or propellers. Steam power moved ships faster and was a more reliable way of transporting people and goods. Today, ships use mainly diesel engines, and their most important job is carrying cargo.

Propeller power
The ship's engine turns a propeller at the back of the ship. This pushes the ship forward. On a big ship, these propellers can be enormous.

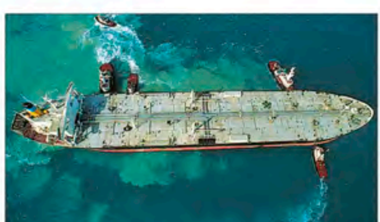
The ship is steered from the wheelhouse.

Living quarters

This part of the ship is called the bridge.

The cruising speed of a ship like this is around 15 knots or 17 mph (28 kmh).

In the dock
In modern ports, like Singapore, most cargo arrives on trucks and trains, and is already packed in containers. These are stored on the docks and can then be neatly loaded onto the ships by cranes.



Pull and tug
Big ships are difficult to control, and from full speed can take several miles just to stop. So in ports and harbors, small, powerful boats called tugs help push and pull big ships safely into position.